

[DC] “SHOW YOUR DEDICATION:” VR Games and Outmersion

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ABSTRACT

Videogame scholarship has noted the unhelpful vagueness of ‘immersion’ as a descriptor, yet in the discourse surrounding VR entertainment, ‘immersion’ remains a central focus, and is lauded by users as the primary goal of VR experiences. Building on the legacy of games scholarship that complicates ‘immersion’ [5, 10] this study uses close-play to examine several emergent tropes in VR experiences that rely on outmersive design: VR suicide, bodily alteration of the avatar, and VR-within-VR. Ultimately, I advocate for increased attention to how VR’s technical capacity for user immersion differs from the reality of many VR experiences that use outmersive design.

Index Terms: Software and its engineering—Contextual software domains—Virtual worlds software—Interactive games; Human-centered computing—Human computer interaction (HCI)—Interaction paradigms—Virtual reality

1 INTRODUCTION

After I died, I pulled the headset off and threw it onto my desk. I paced around my apartment, rattled by what had just happened: the empty white void, the floating gun, the text that read: “SHOW YOUR DEDICATION.” This was the first time I had to kill myself in virtual reality—a moment that has carved a personal impetus for the research I’ve done on VR and embodiment. The game in question is the critically acclaimed title *SUPERHOT VR*, which prompts the player to shoot themselves in the head at several points in the narrative. While the trope of player-suicide is not new to videogames, the implications are significant for VR, a medium which has been increasingly marketed for its immersive potential.

Videogame scholarship has long been obsessed with the way technology can converge the physical and virtual bodies together—but this is a troubled legacy. Digital media scholars focusing on identity [2, 13] have emphasized the ways that technological embodiment is a complex negotiation of identity. And yet, the focus of scholarly discourse surrounding consumer VR (and VR games in particular) remains rooted in its promise of immersion, leaving us without a vocabulary for discussing experiences that are engaging, but not immersive. In this study, I break down how popular VR games are actually *refuting* expectations of embodiment through outmersive design, and the implications this has for development and discussion.

2 THEORY

The term “immersion” poses a problem because of its dual legacy. On the one hand, VR engineers and researchers have used “immersion” to discuss the capacity of VR hardware (especially HMDs) to create a sensation of presence via 3D graphics, sound design, and proprioception for decades [17]. However, a second legacy of “immersion” extends out of media and narrative studies, and has been used to “refer to experiential states as diverse as general engagement, perception of realism, addiction, suspension of disbelief,

identification with game characters, and more” [5, pg. 25]. The latter model for thinking of immersion (explored in Murray’s *Hamlet on the Holodeck* [12, pg. 97]) suggests that “incorporation occurs when the game world is present to the player while the player is simultaneously present, via her avatar, to the virtual environment” [5, pg. 169]. In other words, this idea of immersion involves the user ‘stepping’ from the real to the virtual world. These competing legacies of ‘immersion’ have become blurred: marketing for consumer HMD’s continue to promote their ‘immersive capacity’ and users have come to identify immersion as the *goal* of VR—which (as Bowman and McMahan have pointed out) is not always the case [3].

“Outmersion” is a term coined by Gonzalo Frasca in a 2008 article since removed; he defines outmersion as “analyzing from a distance, not being presently involved in the game activity” [7]. If “immersion” is a catch-all for user being present “inside” their virtual avatar, then we might see “outmersion” as the opposite: a dissonance between user and the avatar. Broadly speaking, outmersive design strives to distance the user from an immersed experience by breaking their attention or drawing their attention outside the experience. I use outmersion here as a model to examine how VR games deliberately deny users their presumed immersion.

3 STUDY DESIGN

This study involved two parts. In the first, I gathered and analyzed several of the most popular video advertisements for commercial VR games from 2016 through 2018 and coded them for their messages about immersion. In the second, I qualitatively analyzed several of the most prominent VR games for commercial HMDs on Steam and the Oculus Store for the purposes of identifying outmersive design tropes. Games were selected based on popularity and intended to include a variety of genres (horror, shooters, social, and RPG). Ultimately, three outmersive tropes were identified: VR suicide, bodily alteration of the avatar, and VR-within-VR. The games were grouped and coded according to these shared tropes.

4 THE PROMISE OF IMMERSION

By scoping the commercial and popular discourse of VR with critical technoculture discourse analysis [4], we can see how the emphasis on immersion put forward by the industry has been adopted by consumers. This analysis revealed three presumptions built into the marketing of VR HMDs and games: a) immersion is the highest priority of the gaming experience, b) immersion is shown as a physically embodied ‘transportation’, and c) immersion involves ‘sacrificing’ or ‘abandoning’ the non-virtual world. I found that many of these advertisements shared an identical structure: a user in a bleak but immaculate living space puts on a HMD and the physical environment around them violently transforms as they are consumed by the virtual environment. This specific pattern happened in numerous ways, such as:

- User sinks into their living room carpet [9].
- User’s walls are melted open by laser portals [14, 15].
- User’s apartment is frozen in a blizzard [8].
- User’s apartment is destroyed in a wormhole [6].
- User’s apartment is smashed by a dragon [16].

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In all these cases, these ads suggested a quality of immersion that was akin to ‘stepping between worlds.’ This marked an emphasis on immersion as a one-way trajectory into virtual spaces realized as a literal, violent transference of the physical user. Digital race scholar Lisa Nakamura noted the problematic nature of early internet advertising as promoting “body tourism” [11]. Yet when we look at modern VR marketing, we see this same problematic representation of immersion as a bodily transference (see Oculus’ “Open Your Eyes” ad as an example of this [1]).

5 FINDINGS: OUTMERSIVE REALITIES

In the second part of my analysis, I examined emerging tropes in virtual reality design for moments that outmersed the player from an embodied experience. All these examples indicate moments that the design of the VR experience has not only subverted user’s expectations of immersion—but (sometimes violently) thrust the user from their embodied experience by reminding them of the simulated nature of their experience or destroying or changing their virtual body.

5.1 Virtual Reality Suicide

This trope involves players being prompted to commit suicide or participate in their own death at fixed points in the narrative. This is decidedly outmersive as the player must disembody themselves.

- *SUPERHOT VR*: The player must shoot themselves at numerous points in the game.
- *Accounting VR*: The player kills themselves via gun, acid, guillotine, bomb, and more.
- *Wilson’s Heart*: The player/Wilson is killed off by euthanasia at the end of the game.

5.2 Bodily Alteration

This trope marks instances where players must perform alterations to their virtual body that their physical body cannot identify with and that cannot be imitated by the technology of the headset.

- *Wilson’s Heart*: The player must remove their own heart, saw off their own arm, and pull screws from their head.
- *The Gallery: Call of the Starseed* and *Heart of the Emberstone*: The player’s hands are violently replaced with empowered mechanical ones.
- *Asgard’s Wrath*: The player moves between bodies as they possess other characters.
- *Trover Saves the Universe*: The player controls the protagonist as a seated “chairorphan” from a distance.

5.3 Bodily Alteration

This especially prominent trope notes a rising trend of nesting other layers of simulation within virtual reality (sometimes simulated headsets, but also by other means) reminding the user of the simulated experience they are participating in.

- *SUPERHOT VR*: The player selects levels from in-game VR helmet.
- *Accounting VR*: The player travels deeper into layers of virtual reality and must escape at the end.
- *Rec Room*: The games are staged as theatre productions.
- *Lone Echo*: The game uses tutorials as nested simulations.
- *Duck Season*: Missions take place inside a TV console.
- *Oculus Home*: Oculus’ home menu uses a virtual console.

6 LIMITATIONS/CHALLENGES

This project is necessarily still in-progress. Further work will be done in scraping Steam and Oculus’ webstores for more quantitative data to supplement the argument. Additionally, new layers of discussion about how VR’s design, from a technical standpoint—especially with regard to kinesthetic involvement, movement, haptics, and design—will be required. This will allow me to map additional layers of nuance on how outmersion might be more actively applied to virtual reality application design. Notably, my study so far has examined only games for VR headsets targeted at consumers. While this has proved a useful avenue for quickly exploring larger tropes, this work will need to be extended beyond HMD systems and include other applications. Because projection-based systems and MR offer different kinds of user embodiment, it will be important to see if these expectations of immersion are rooted predominantly in headset-specific discourse. Finally, there are implications for this work on the field of social justice and empathy-driven VR experiences (which similarly rely on preconceptions of an immersed user).

7 CONCLUSION

For VR developers, engineers, and designers, it will be increasingly necessary to recognize that—while VR systems grow their technical capacity for user-immersion—VR entertainment is not always designed to be immersive. In fact, the tropes identified in this study indicate that VR design for games frequently relies on experiences that separate users from their avatars via suicide, bodily alteration, and VR-within-VR. This is especially important because commercial HMDs are being marketed to consumers and businesses for their immersive capacity, but this promise of immersion does not always extend to the VR experiences themselves. If users expect to be ‘immersed’ (in the pop culture sense) through VR, they may find experiences that deliberately break that immersion (especially troubling ones like VR suicide) difficult or shocking as a result.

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